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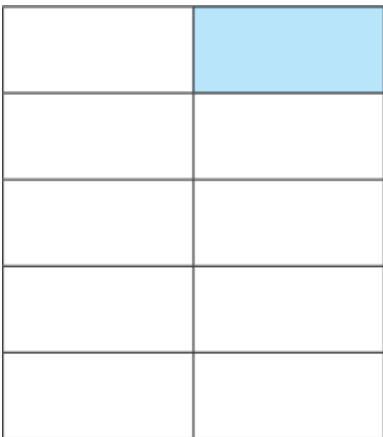
Comparing Decimals

Because you use money every day, you know that \$0.50 is more than \$0.05. Fifty cents is more than 5 cents because 50 is greater than 5. When you take away the dollar sign, these decimals are written as 0.5 and 0.05, and 0.5 still has the greater value.

As you move farther to the right of the decimal point, the value of the digits gets smaller.

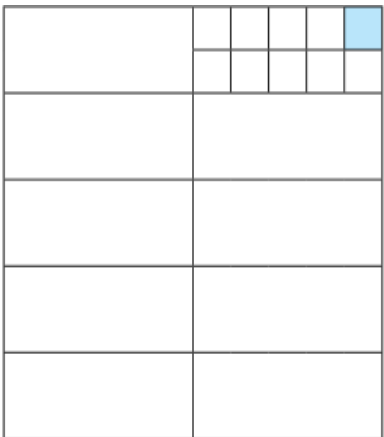
One tenth 0.1

The box below is divided into 10 equal parts. One tenth is shaded.



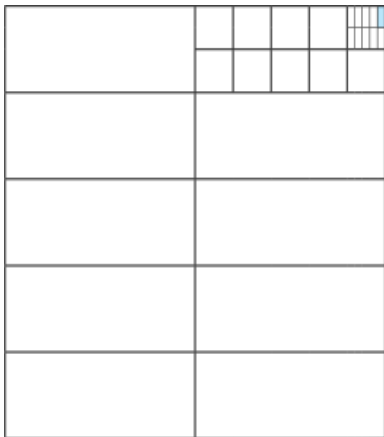
One hundredth 0.01

Each tenth in the previous box is divided into 10 equal parts. One hundredth is shaded.



One thousandth 0.001

Imagine dividing each hundredth in the previous box into 10 equal parts and then shading only 1 of those parts. One thousandth is shaded.



To compare decimals, use this important fact: Adding zeros to the end of a decimal does not change its value. The numbers 0.6 and 0.600 are equal.

Example 1

Hide

Which is greater: 0.85 or 0.69?
Both numbers have the same number of decimal places. That is, both numbers are *hundredths*. Compare as you would with whole numbers.
0.85 is greater than 0.69 because 85 is greater than 69.

$$0.85 > 0.69$$

Example 2

Hide

Which is greater: 0.4 or 0.215?
Step 1
Add zeros so that both numbers have the same number of decimal places: thousandths.
0.400 Adding zeros to the right of the last digit does not change the value of the decimal.
0.215
Step 2
Compare the decimals as if they were whole numbers. 400 is greater than 215, so 0.4 is greater than 0.215.

$$0.4 > 0.215$$

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Category

Lesson 1: Number Sense

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